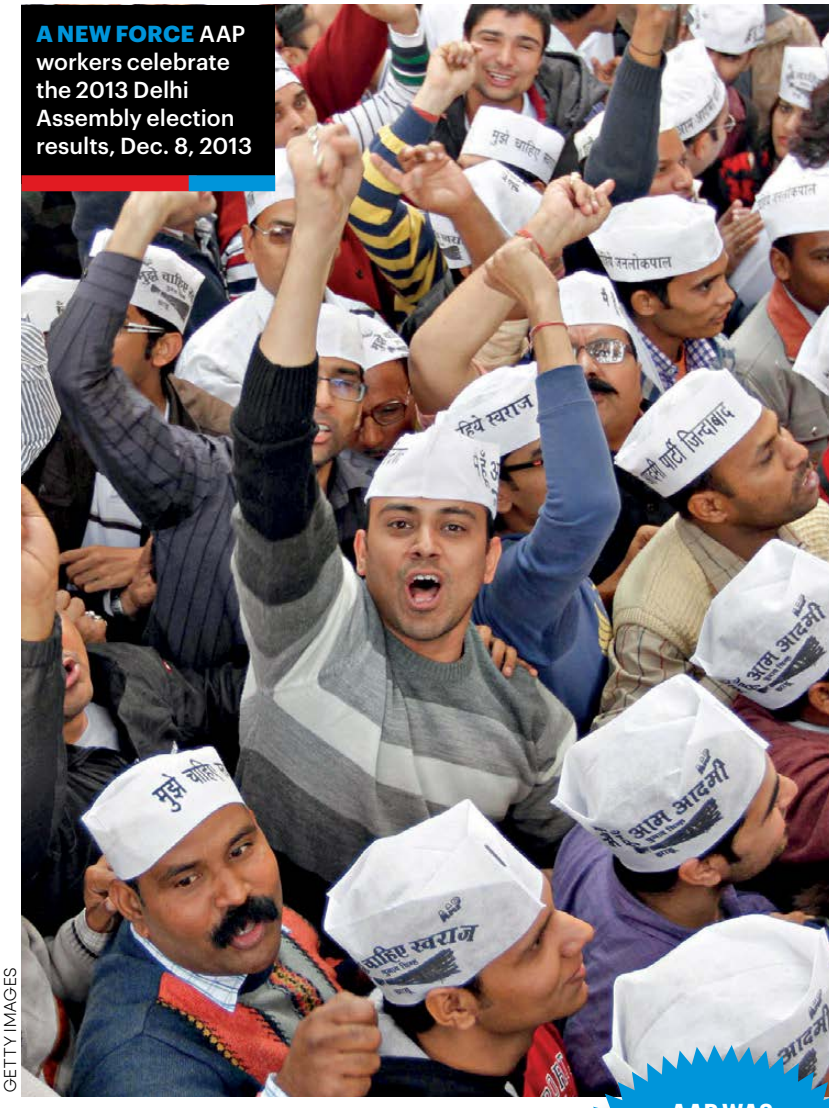


A NEW FORCE AAP workers celebrate the 2013 Delhi Assembly election results, Dec. 8, 2013

GETTY IMAGES

Why Everyone is Afraid of Arvind Kejriwal
Oct. 29, 2012

"The urban middle class should be very afraid of Kejriwal's economic agenda. He threatens to turn upside down the one institution that has delivered prosperity for the middle class, despite the government, in the two decades since liberalisation—the free market. IAC's Vision Document, which will form the basis of the future political party's agenda, is quite clear when it says that development cannot be guided by the "logic of capital" or forces of the "free market"."



AAP WAS FORMALLY LAUNCHED IN NOV 2012. ITS SYMBOL, THE BROOM, SIGNALLED CLEANSING, HUMILITY AND DOMESTIC FAMILIARITY

Yet the movement also revealed its limits. While Hazare wanted moral pressure without political ambition, Kejriwal drew a different conclusion that protest alone could not dismantle what he called "collusive corruption" between parties. Politics had to be entered, not merely influenced. It split the movement but gave birth to a political project.

By late 2012, Kejriwal had repositioned himself from activist to challenger. His public exposés of figures across party lines were designed to reinforce a single message: the system was rotten and only an outsider could clean it. Kejriwal's strength lay not in charisma or organisational muscle but in fearlessness and ordinariness. He threatened reputations using documents rather than slogans and framed himself as a citizen armed with facts rather than power.

AAP was formally launched in November 2012 with a deliberately anti-political vocabulary. Its symbol, the broom, was not incidental. It signalled cleansing, humility and domestic familiarity. Its candidates were deliberately ordinary, its funding crowdsourced and its campaign aggressively low-budget. The party spoke the language of betrayal rather than ideology.

The breakthrough came in the December 2013 Delhi assembly election. AAP, contesting its first election, won 28 seats, finishing second ahead of the Congress and just short of the BJP. It was a political shock. Sheila Dikshit's three-term government collapsed and the Congress was reduced to a marginal force in the capital. AAP's support came disproportionately from the urban middle class, slum-dwellers and first-time voters, united less by identity than by anger at corruption and high living costs.

Kejriwal's brief 49-day stint as chief minister in early 2014 was chaotic and symbolic. His decision to resign over the Jan Lokpal Bill reinforced his image as a protester unwilling to compromise, even at the cost of power. Critics saw irresponsibility, supporters saw integrity.

Kejriwal's most audacious gamble came when he attempted to take his anti-corruption politics national by directly challenging Narendra Modi in the 2014 Lok Sabha election from Varanasi. Kejriwal's defeat underlined a structural truth. Anti-corruption crusade was insufficient on its own to counter a pan-India narrative built on authority, organisation and ideological clarity. ■